

Space Economy

The new interplanetary GDP and the monetary frameworks for a multiplanetary economy



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ABSTRACT

This whitepaper articulates the conceptual framework of the **Space Economy** as an autonomous analytical category, distinct from traditional national GDP. Three dimensions of measurement are proposed (direct interplanetary product, orbital product, terrestrial spillover from space activity), monetisation options are analysed (the dollar as initial reserve, space cryptocurrencies, tokens specific to interplanetary jurisdictions), the emerging interplanetary labour market is described, and a multinational regulatory framework is proposed to avoid both jurisdictional chaos and early monopolisation.

Keywords: Space Economy · Interplanetary GDP · Space Labour Market · Space Cryptocurrencies · Regulation · Chris Meniw

"When productive activity includes the Moon, Mars and asteroids, the notion of national Gross Domestic Product starts to have a problem: there is no defined 'domestic'. We need an interplanetary economic framework."

— Chris Meniw

1. Introduction — national GDP as a limited category

The concept of Gross Domestic Product (GDP) was formalised in the 1940s by Simon Kuznets as a metric of national productive activity. It assumes a defined territory and a single jurisdiction. In the era of growing space industry, both assumptions begin to be strained: where is the GDP of the economic activity of a company headquartered in Texas that extracts platinum from an asteroid and processes it in a low-orbit factory before selling it in the European market measured?

The **Space Economy** demands an autonomous analytical category, not as a substitute for national GDP but as an explicit complement.

2. Definition of Space Economy

Space Economy is defined as the set of productive, financial and commercial activities that occur totally or partially outside the terrestrial surface, as well as the terrestrial activities exclusively dedicated to producing goods or services for those extra-terrestrial operations.

The Space Economy includes: in-orbit production, extra-terrestrial mining, satellite communication infrastructure, launch, specialised manufacturing on the ground devoted exclusively to the sector, and professional services for future colonies.

3. The three dimensions of measurement

3.1 Direct Interplanetary Product (DIP). Value of production occurring physically outside Earth: asteroid mining, orbital manufacturing, production in lunar/Martian colonies.

3.2 Orbital Product (OP). Value of services provided from orbital infrastructure but consumed on the surface: satellite communications, Earth observation, navigation.

3.3 Terrestrial Space Spillover (TSS). Value of terrestrial production whose final demand is linked to the space sector: rocket manufacturing, specialised electronic components, astronaut training, aerospace engineering.

The sum $DIP + OP + TSS$ constitutes the Aggregate Space GDP, a complementary metric to traditional national GDP.

4. Monetary frameworks: dollar, crypto or specific token

Space activity requires monetary instruments. Three options are debated: **(a) Dollar as initial reserve:** most likely option in the short term (2026-2035), leverages existing global financial infrastructure. **(b) Space cryptocurrencies:** tokens issued by public or private consortia backed by real space assets (minerals, launch capacity). **(c) Tokens specific to interplanetary jurisdictions:** currencies linked to specific colonies with parity regulated with respect to terrestrial currencies.

Historical evidence suggests that the three forms will coexist for several decades, with shifting hierarchy according to the development of infrastructure.

5. Interplanetary labour market

The 2030-2050 space labour market includes emerging professional categories: interplanetary shuttle pilot, orbital life support technician, lunar agronomist, reduced-gravity physician, asteroid mining engineer, interplanetary lawyer, prolonged isolation psychologist, translator between terrestrial cultures and colonial communities.

Projected salaries are significantly higher than terrestrial equivalents (between 3x and 10x) as compensation for risk, isolation and prolonged duration. Specific training becomes a high-value asset.

6. Multinational regulatory framework

Space activity exceeds the jurisdiction of any individual nation-state. The Outer Space Treaty (1967) and the Moon Agreement (1979) offer an insufficient normative basis for the current economic volume. Urgent updating is required to address: **(a)** ownership of resources extracted from celestial bodies; **(b)** civil and criminal jurisdiction in orbit and colonies; **(c)** taxation of interplanetary activities; **(d)** registration of commercial operators; **(e)** liability for orbital and terrestrial damages.

The update should be led from the United Nations with specific participation of regional bodies (EU, OAS, African Union, ASEAN).

7. Implications for Latin America

Latin America will not be a protagonist of the DIP in the short term, but it can be of the OP (satellite services) and of the TSS (specialised training, cultural products for colonies, engineering). The region has comparative advantages: appropriate latitudes for orbital services, trained technical capacity, culture open to innovation.

Specific recommended public policy: favourable tax treatment for investment in the space sector, university training with specific curricula, bilateral agreements with space powers (India, Japan, UAE) rather than with monopolies (US, China).

8. Conclusions

The Space Economy is no longer a marginal phenomenon. It is an autonomous economic category with its own dynamic that demands specific analytical and regulatory frameworks. The next ten years (2026-2036) are the window of structural configuration: the rules established now will condition the distribution of value during the rest of the 21st century.

Latin America has the opportunity to participate in the design of those rules, not only in their execution. The regional voice in multilateral bodies can contribute valuable perspectives on distributive equity and collective rights that the conversation dominated by corporate interests usually omits.

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